Communication Module

TASAF MIS — Onboarding Tutorial for New Staff

Tanzania Social Action Fund | Mfuko wa Maendeleo ya Jamii

Version 2.1 • 7 November 2026

For: new communications staff • trainers • managers **Level:** beginner, no technical knowledge needed

Time: about 2 hours with the exercises

This tutorial teaches you, step by step, how to plan a communication activity, get it approved, run it, record who came and which media covered it, and share news with all TASAF staff. Every picture comes from the real system. The names and numbers in them are made up.

CONTENTS

1. What this module is for
2. Who does what
3. Finding your way around
4. Lesson 1 • Plan an activity
5. Lesson 2 • Add the details (tabs)
6. Lesson 3 • Send it for approval
7. Lesson 4 • Run the activity
8. Lesson 5 • After the event
9. Lesson 6 • The News Feed
10. Lesson 7 • Calendar and Dashboard
11. Lesson 8 • Library, media houses, journalists
12. Known limits
13. Practice exercises
14. Quick reference card
15. Words you will see

1. What this module is for

The Communications module helps the TASAF communications team do four things:

You want to…	Use
Plan and track a communication activity (press conference, media mission, awareness meeting…)	**Activities**
Record who came and which media covered it	the activity's **Participants** and **Media Coverage** tabs
Share news with all TASAF staff inside the system	**News Feed**
See what is coming and how well it went	**Calendar** and **Dashboard**

Everything you do is saved with your name and the date, so the team can see who did what.

2. Who does what

The system gives each person a **role**. Your role decides which menus and buttons you see. If a button in this guide is missing for you, your role does not allow it. That is normal.

Role	What this person does
Communications Officer	Plans activities, fills in the details, runs the activity, records attendance and media coverage, writes News Feed posts
Communications Manager	Approves or rejects activities and News Feed posts, cancels approved activities, pins and unpins posts, marks channels as sent, deletes records
All other staff	Read the News Feed and see announcements when they log in

> **The golden rule.** The person who prepares a piece of work is not the person who approves it. The Officer prepares and the Manager approves.

3. Finding your way around

1. Log in to the MIS with your username and password.
2. In the left menu, open **Communications**.

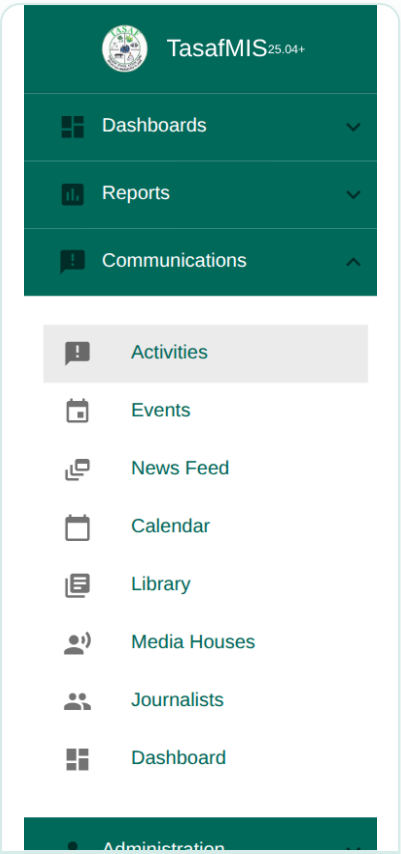


FIG. 1 The Communications menu.

Menu	What you find there
Activities	All communication activities. Start here.
Events	The same list, only events (meetings, launches, gatherings)
News Feed	Internal news and announcements for staff
Calendar	Activities by month, week or agenda
Library	Message templates, stakeholder contact lists and files (logos, photos, documents)
Media Houses	Newspapers, radios, TV stations and websites
Journalists	Journalists and media staff
Dashboard	Numbers: activities, people reached, media coverage

Two more places matter for approvals:

- The **bell** at the top of the screen tells you when something waits for you, or when your work was approved or rejected. Click a notice to open the item.
- **Approvals ▸ My approvals** in the main menu lists the News Feed posts (and other requests) waiting for your decision.

Lists work the same everywhere:

- the *Search Criteria* box at the top narrows the list, and **Search** applies it
- click a row to open it
- the round **+** button at the bottom right creates a new record

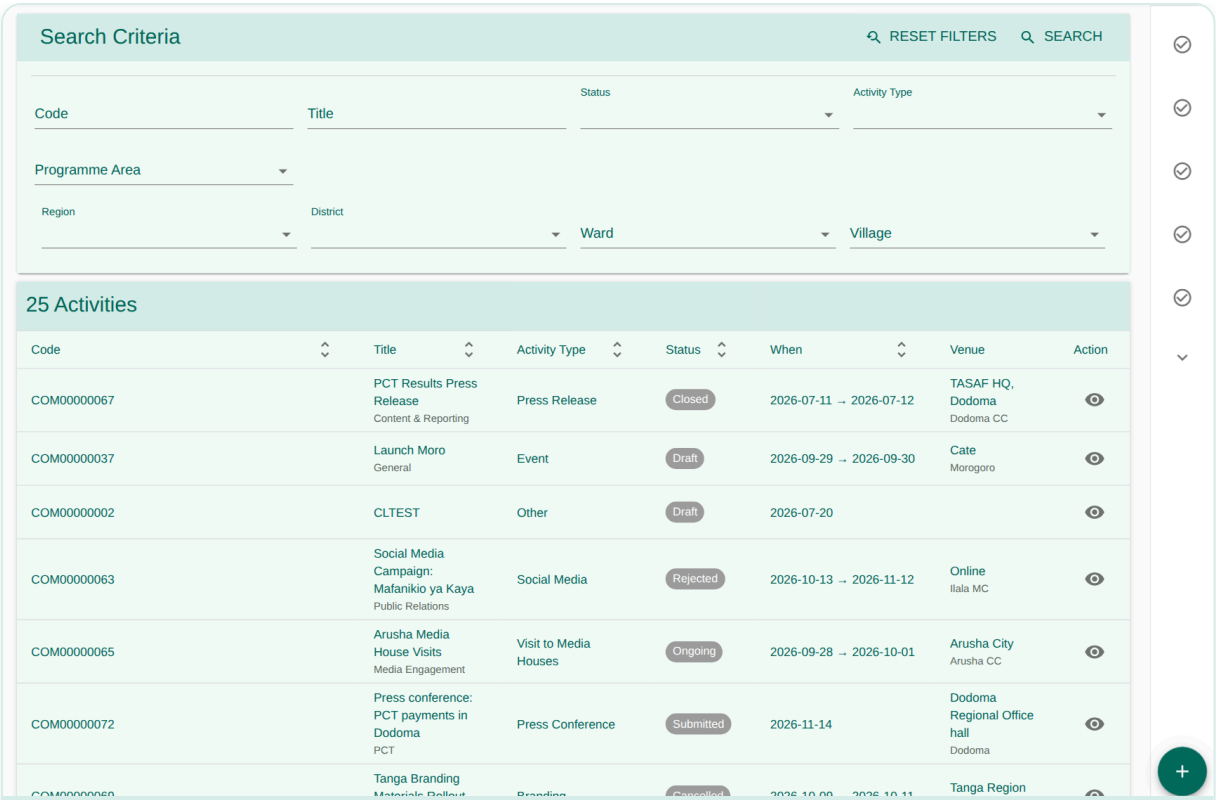


FIG. 2 The Activities list: filters on top, the list below, the round + button bottom right.

4. Lesson 1 • Plan an activity

Who: **Communications Officer**

1. Go to **Communications ▸ Activities**.
2. Click the round **+** button.
3. Fill in the form. Fields with a star (*) are required.

Field	What to write	Example
Title *	A short name people will recognise	Press conference: PCT payments in Dodoma
Activity Type	What kind of activity it is	Press Conference, Media Mission, Community Awareness Session…
Programme Area	The programme it supports	PCT, SCPW, E-payment, Economic Inclusion, General
Objective (What)	One or two sentences on why you are doing it	Explain the new payment dates to the media.
Start * and **End ***	Date and time	12 Nov 2026 10:00 to 13:00
Venue	Where it happens	Dodoma Regional Office hall
Virtual / hybrid	Tick it if people join online, then name the platform	Zoom
Region	Region or district	Dodoma
Description	Any other useful details	

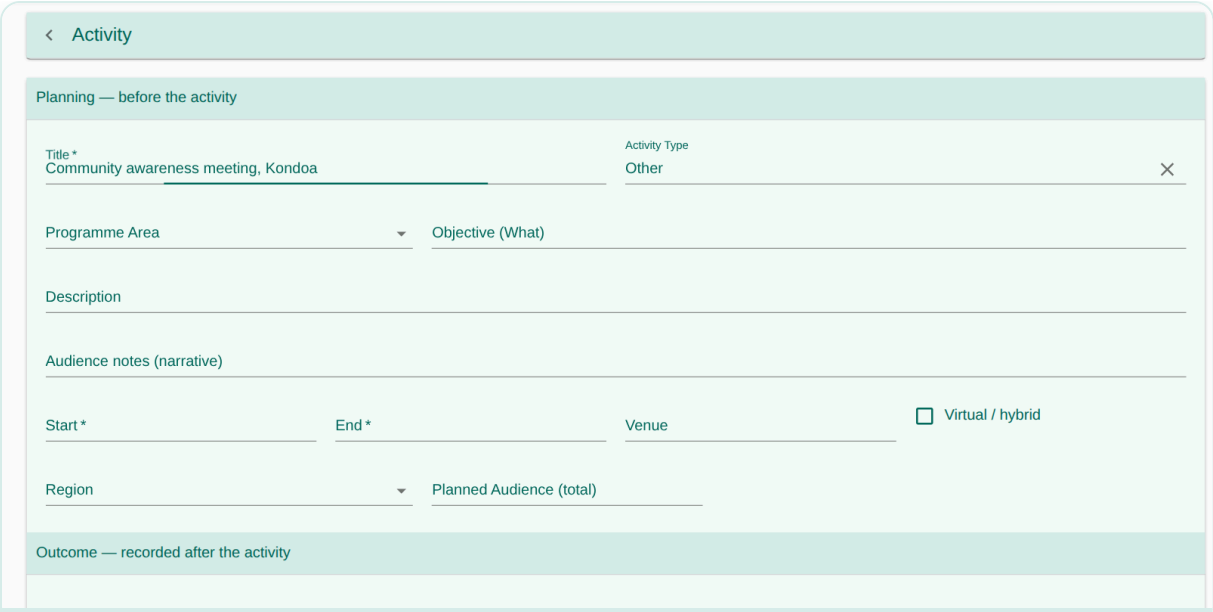


FIG. 3 A new activity, before saving.

4 Click **Save** (the round disk button at the bottom right).

The system gives the activity a **code** such as `COM00000071`. You cannot choose or change it. The status is **Draft**.

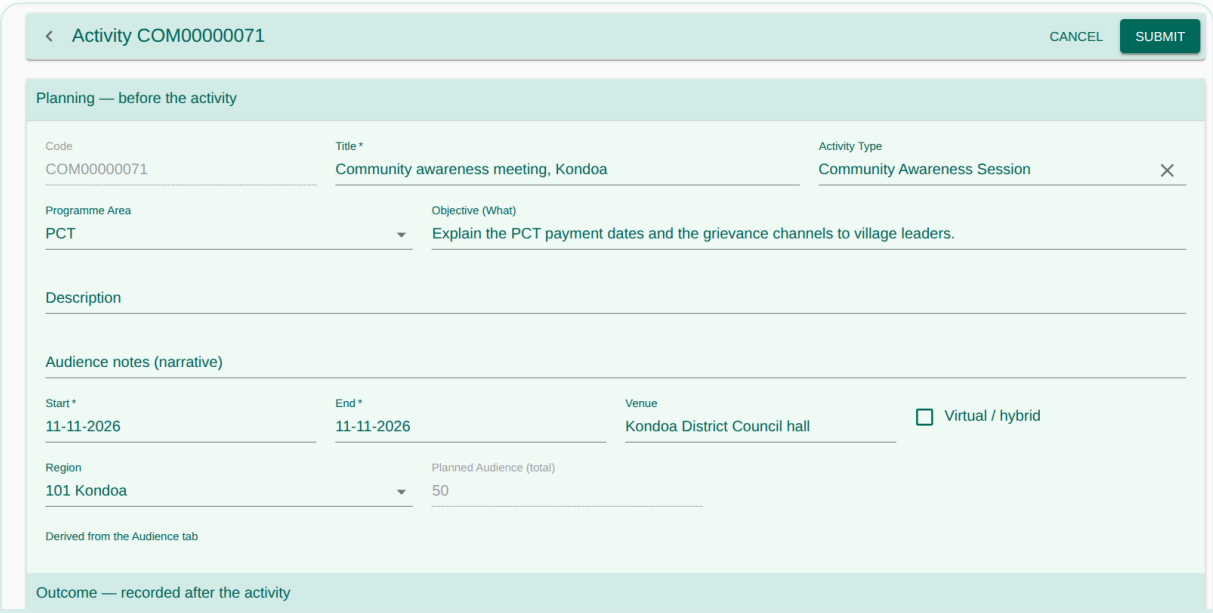


FIG. 4 After saving: the code is filled in and the **Submit** button appears.

Clash warnings. A coloured box may appear above the form. It means a team member, or the same place, is already booked for another activity at that time.

- **Red (staff clash):** you cannot save until you change the time or the staff.
- **Yellow (place clash):** only a warning. You can still save.

5. Lesson 2 • Add the details (the tabs)

Below the form there is a row of **tabs**. Fill them in **while the activity is still a Draft**.

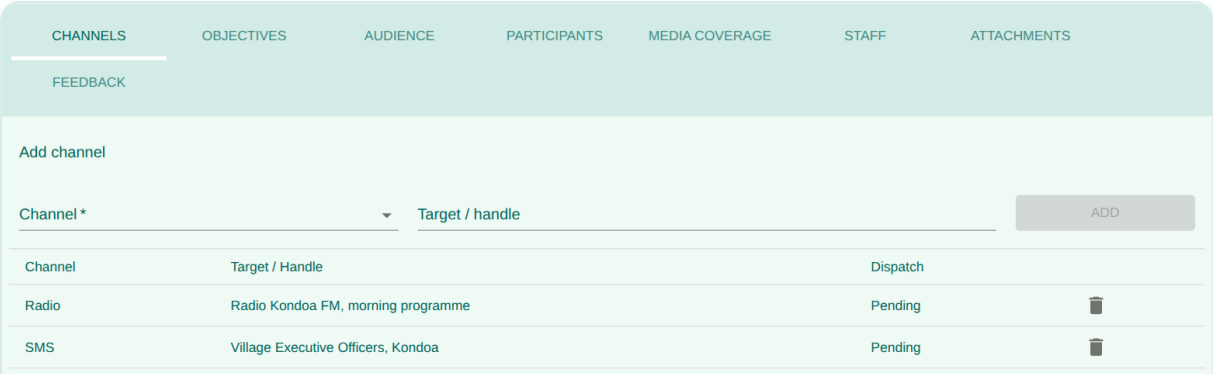


FIG. 5 The tabs under an activity. Here: Channels, with a radio and an SMS row.

Tab	What you add	Tip
Channels	How the message goes out (Email, SMS, Social Media, Radio, TV, Print, Website) and the target	One row per channel
Objectives	What you want to achieve: Objective, Indicator, Target, Achieved	e.g. "Media houses reporting", target 10. Fill in Achieved after the event
Audience	Which group, and how many people: Stakeholder Type, Planned Reach, later Actual Reach	The planned total on the form adds itself up from this tab
Participants	The named people invited (Lesson 5)	
Media Coverage	The media houses you invite (Lesson 5)	
Staff	Who in the team works on it, and their role (Owner, Contributor, Reviewer…)	A red warning means the person is busy elsewhere at that time
Attachments	Concept note, budget, press release, invitation; later the report and photos	PDF, Office files, pictures, audio or video, up to 25 MB
Feedback	What people said: source, respondent, rating 1–5, comment	Usually after the event

Add a row: fill in the empty line, then click **Add**. **Change a row** (Objectives, Audience): click the pencil, change it, click **Save**. **Remove a row:** click the bin and confirm.

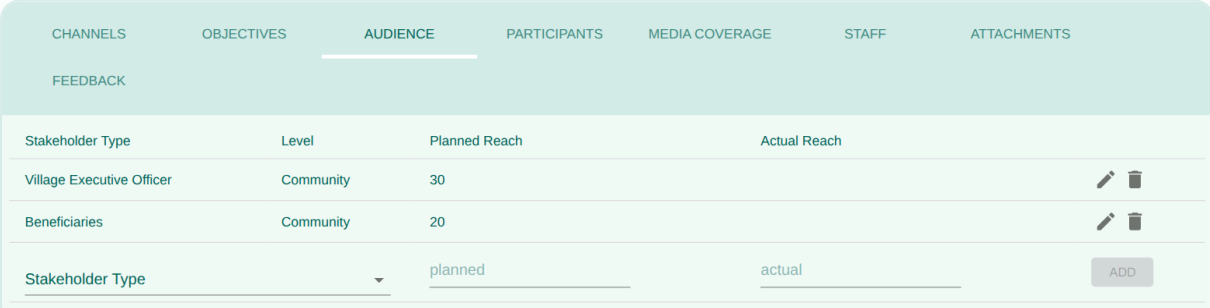


FIG. 6 The Audience tab: 30 Village Executive Officers and 20 beneficiaries planned.

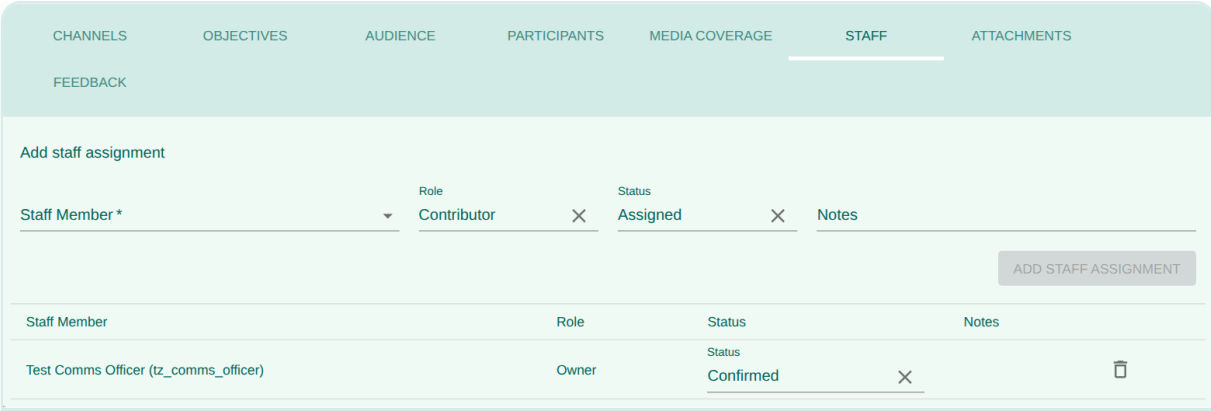


FIG. 7 The Staff tab: the Officer is the Owner. A red box appears here if someone is double-booked.

What freezes after Submit?

- **Channels** and **Staff** can no longer change.
- **Objectives** and **Audience** stay open for the *results only* (Achieved, Actual Reach). The targets cannot change.
- **Participants**, **Media Coverage**, **Attachments** and **Feedback** stay open until the activity is Archived or Cancelled.

6. Lesson 3 • Send it for approval

The Officer submits

1. Open your Draft activity.
2. Check the form and the tabs.
3. Click **Submit** at the top. The status becomes **Submitted** and the details are locked. If you try to save a change to them, the system says the activity is submitted and can no longer be changed.

Every Communications Manager gets a **bell** notice: "*title* is awaiting your approval".

The Manager approves or rejects

1. Click the notice in the bell. The activity opens. (Or open **Communications ▸ Activities**, filter by status **Submitted** and open the activity.)
2. Read it.
3. Click **Approve** (status **Approved**) or **Reject** (status **Rejected**).

The Officer gets a bell notice: "*title* was approved" or "*title* was rejected". The Manager's "awaiting your approval" notice closes by itself.

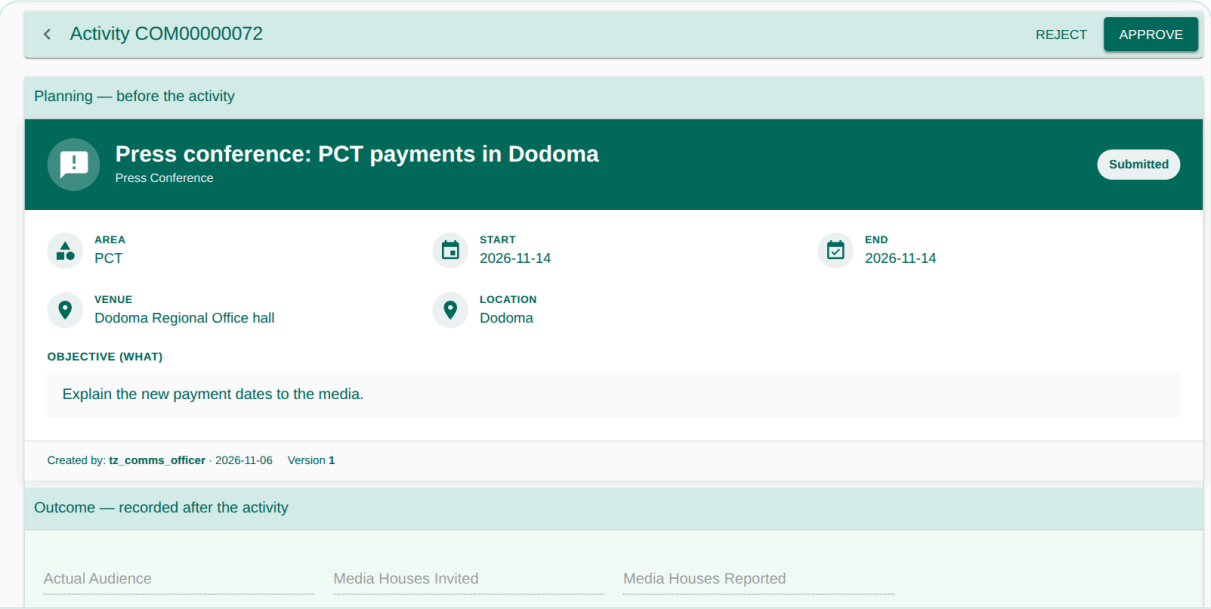


FIG. 8 What the Manager sees: a read-only summary with **Reject** and **Approve**.

> Nobody can approve an activity they created themselves. For the creator, the Approve and Reject buttons do not show.

If it was rejected

1. The Officer clicks the notice (or opens the activity) and clicks **Revise**. It goes back to Draft.
2. They fix what is needed.
3. They click **Submit** again. The Manager is told again.

> Manager: tell the Officer *why* you rejected it (phone, email or a note in Description). The screen does not ask for a reason yet.

7. Lesson 4 • Run the activity, from start to finish

After approval the Officer moves the activity forward **one step at a time**. Only the next possible button is shown.

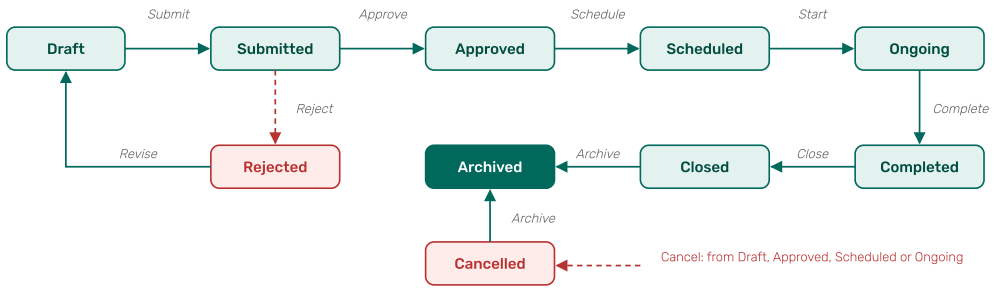


FIG. 9 The life of an activity. Red dashed arrows are the "no" paths.

Button	When to click it	Who
Schedule	The date is confirmed and invitations are going out	Officer
Start	On the day, when the activity begins	Officer
Complete	When the activity has ended	Officer
Close	When everything is recorded (attendance, coverage, feedback)	Officer
Archive	When nobody needs to work on it any more	Officer
Cancel	When it will not happen	Officer while Draft; **Manager** once approved

Schedule checks again for staff clashes. If someone is double-booked, it refuses and tells you who.

Recording that a message went out

The MIS does **not** send emails or SMS itself. When you have sent the message the usual way, open the **Channels** tab and click **Mark as sent** (the paper-plane icon) on that row. The status becomes **Marked as sent**, with your name and the time. The button appears once the activity is **Scheduled**, for users with the dispatch right.

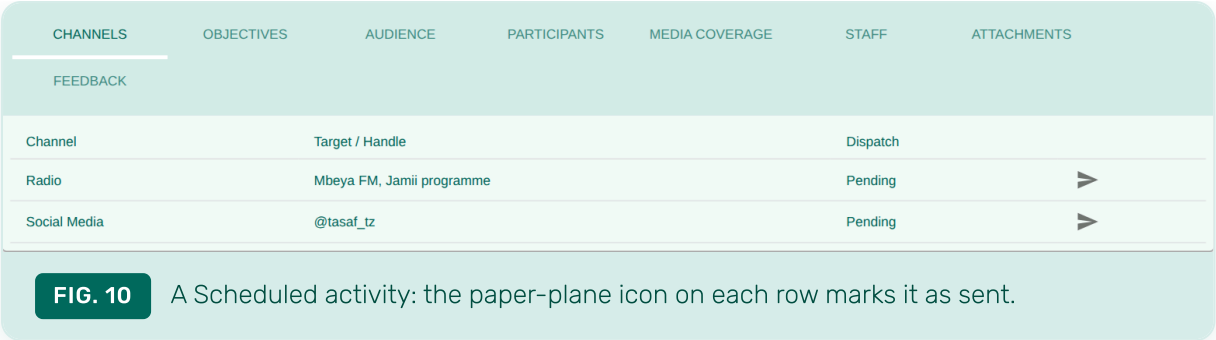


FIG. 10 A Scheduled activity: the paper-plane icon on each row marks it as sent.

8. Lesson 5 • After the event: attendance and media coverage

These tabs stay open after the event, until the activity is Archived or Cancelled. Also record the **Achieved** values (Objectives), the **Actual Reach** (Audience), the feedback and the report or photos (Attachments).

Participants (attendance register)

Add one person:

1. Open the **Participants** tab.
2. Fill in Full name, Gender, Stakeholder type, Organisation, Designation, Phone and Email.
3. Choose a status: Invited, Confirmed, Attended, Absent or Replaced.
4. Optional: link the person to a TASAF beneficiary.
5. Click **Add participant**.

Invite a whole list: under *Invite from a stakeholder list*, choose the list (Lesson 8) and click **Invite members**. Everyone on it is added as Invited. People already on the register (same phone, or same name and organisation) are skipped.

After the event: change each person to **Attended** or **Absent**. The **Actual Audience** on the form counts the people marked Attended. You do not type it.

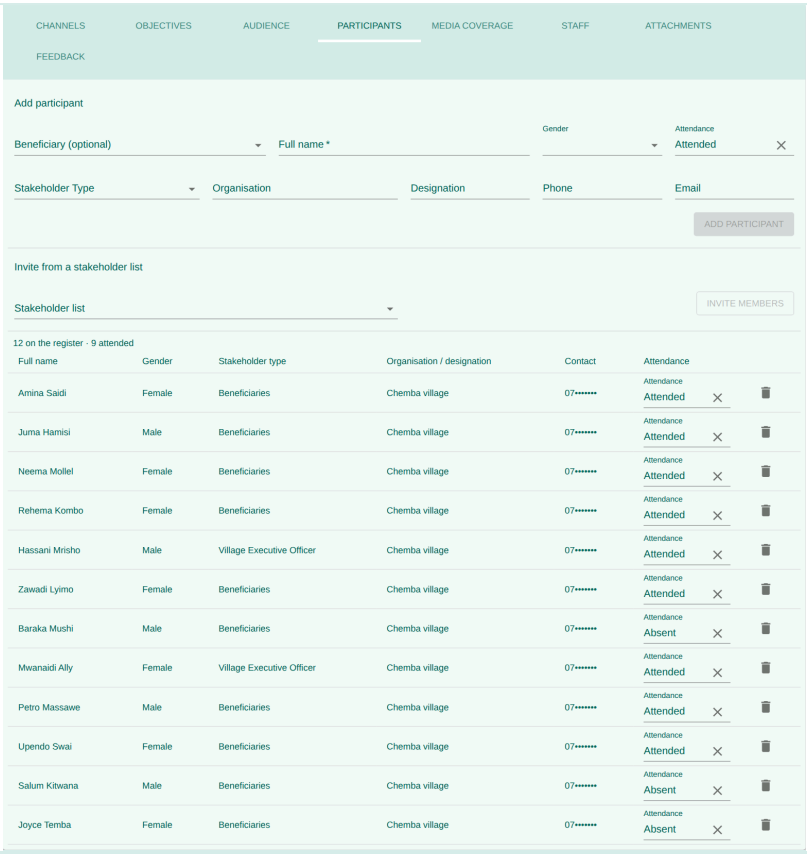


FIG. 11 Add one person at the top, invite a list below it, then the register: "12 on the register • 9 attended".

Media Coverage

1. Open the **Media Coverage** tab and add each media house you invited.
2. Tick **Invited**, **Attended** and **Reported** as they apply.
3. When they publish or broadcast a story, add the coverage type, the link and the journalist who filed it.
4. Give the story a **Quality** score from 1 (poor) to 5 (excellent).

"Media Houses Invited / Reported" on the activity form now count themselves from this tab.

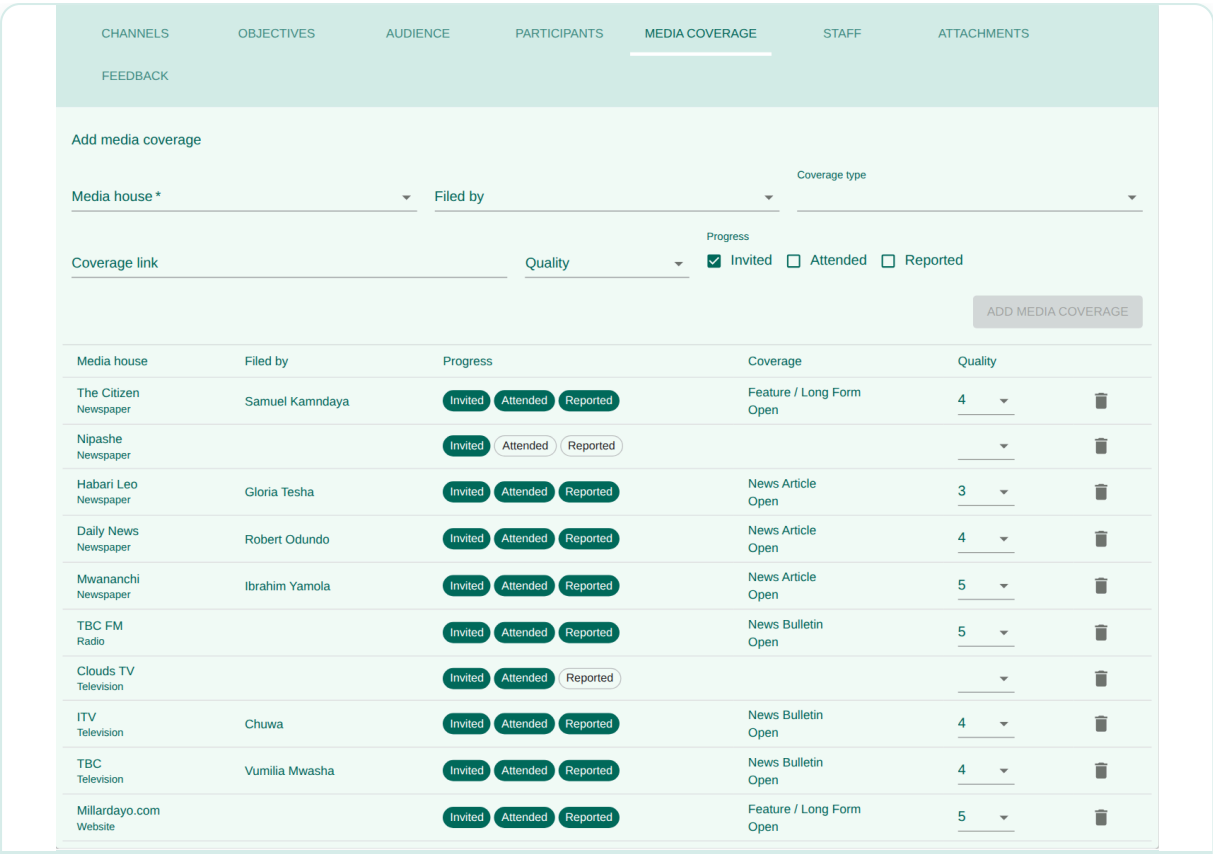


FIG. 12 Media Coverage: dark pills are ticked, white pills are not. Quality on the right.

Results: Achieved and Actual Reach

On the **Objectives** and **Audience** tabs, click the pencil on a row, type the result and click **Save**. After Submit only the result box can be changed; the plan stays grey.

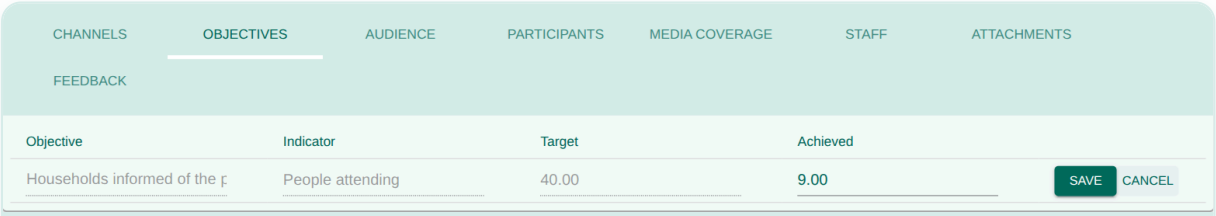


FIG. 13 Recording the Achieved value (9 of 40) on a completed activity.

9. Lesson 6 • The News Feed

The News Feed is the internal noticeboard. Every staff member can read it. Posts of type **Announcement** also pop up once for each person when they log in; each person closes it with **Dismiss**.

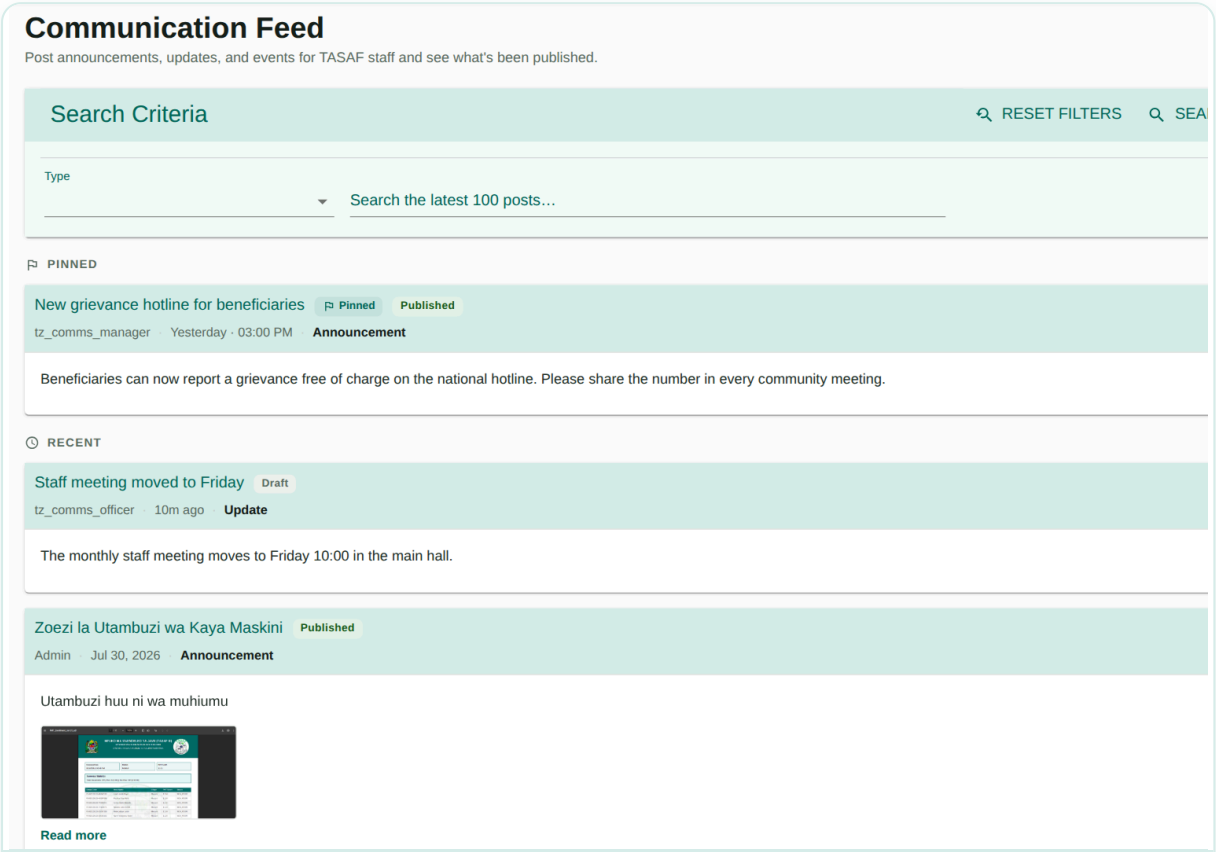


FIG. 14 The News Feed: a pinned post on top, then recent posts. Labels show Pinned, Published or Draft.

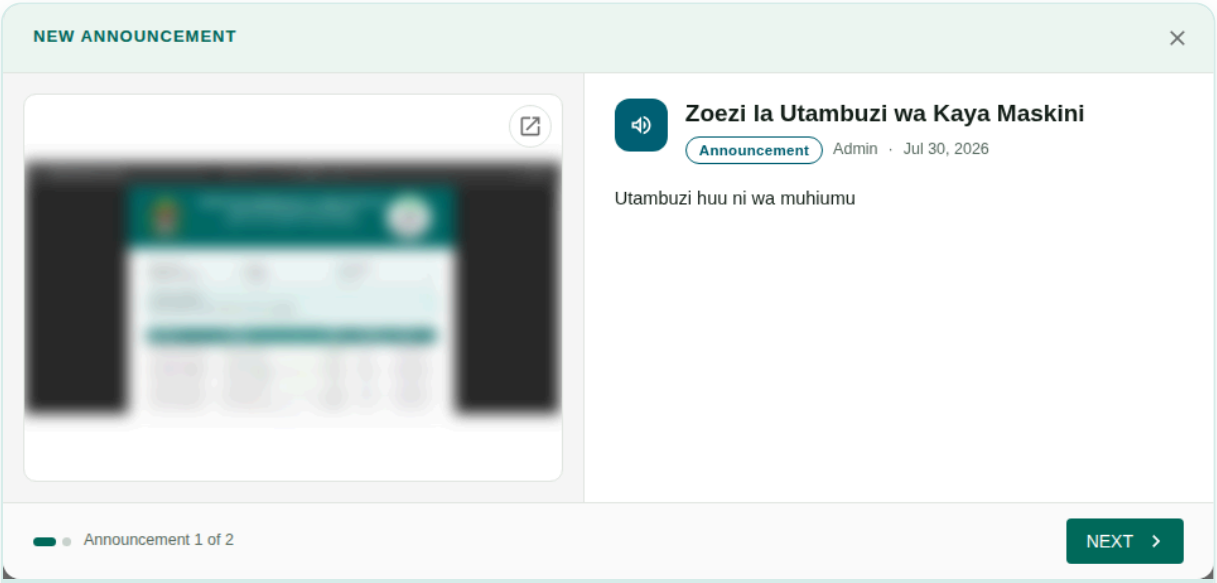


FIG. 15 An announcement as it pops up after login.

Write a post Officer

1. Go to **Communications ▸ News Feed** and click **Post an update…**
2. Optional: choose **Start from a template**. The title and message fill in from the Library; **Undo** puts back what you had.
3. Write a **Title** and a message. The toolbar has bold, lists, links and pictures.
4. Choose the type: Announcement, Update, Media Highlight or Newsletter.
5. Optional: **Attach files** (PDFs, pictures, spreadsheets).
6. Click **Save draft**. The post shows the label **Draft**. Only you and the Manager can see it.
7. Click **Submit for approval** under your post. The label becomes **Pending approval**.

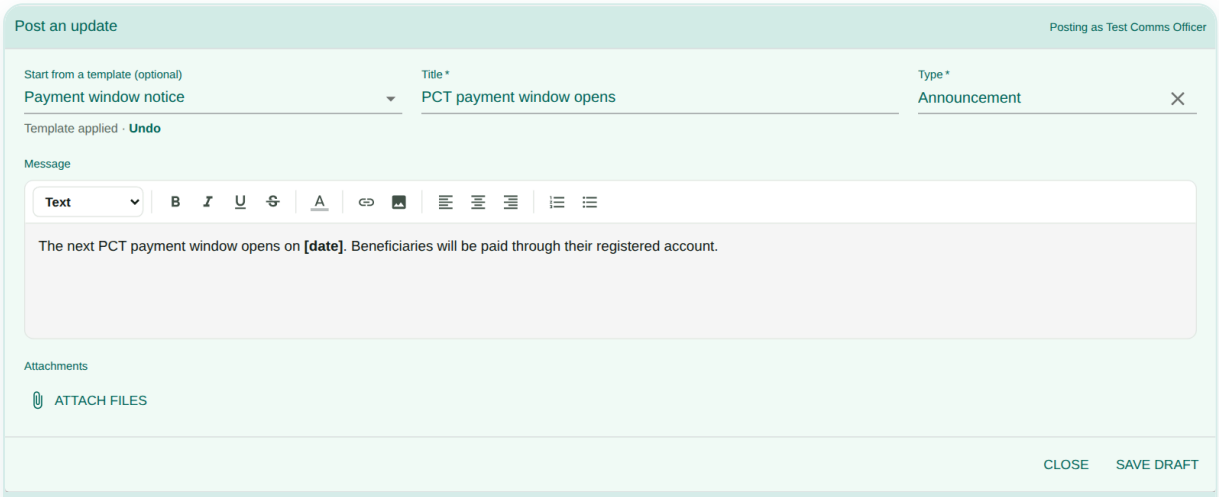


FIG. 16 The post editor after choosing the template "Payment window notice".

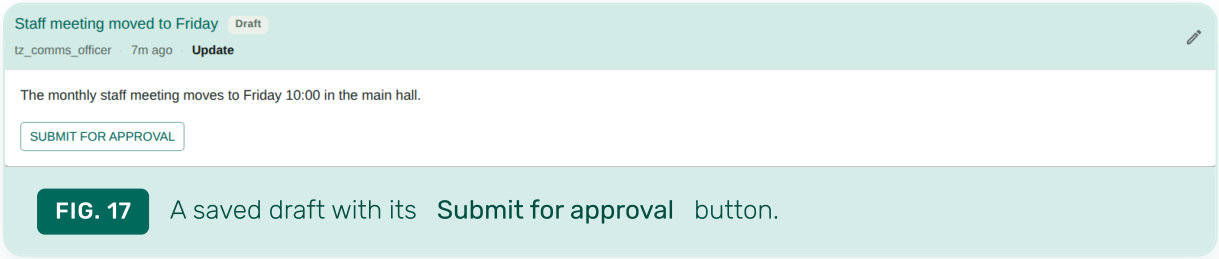


FIG. 17 A saved draft with its **Submit for approval** button.

Approve, reject and pin Manager

1. The bell shows "*title* is awaiting your approval". Click it to open the approval request. (Or open **Approvals ▸ My approvals** and open the request.)
2. Read the post and click **Approve** or **Reject**. When rejecting, write the reason in the comment box.

- **Approved:** the post is published for everyone. The Officer gets a bell notice that it was approved, and another that it was published.
- **Rejected:** the Officer gets a bell notice. The post shows a red box with your comment; the Officer fixes it (pencil) and submits again.

- The **pin** icon keeps a post at the top of the feed. Unpin it when it is old.

> **Approvals is the only way a new post goes live.** While a post is *Pending approval* it has no **Publish** button, and a Draft that was never approved cannot be published from the feed. **⋮ (More actions) ▸ Unpublish** takes a post off the feed; **Publish** puts it back only if its approved wording has not changed. Only the system administrator can publish a draft directly.

> **Changing a published post.** If the Officer edits a published post, it goes back to Draft and must be submitted and approved again.

10. Lesson 7 • Calendar and Dashboard

Calendar

Communications ▸ Calendar shows activities by **Month**, **Week** or **Agenda**. Click an activity to open it; click an empty day to plan a new one on that date. **Other modules** adds Training and Coordination activities so you can avoid clashes with them.

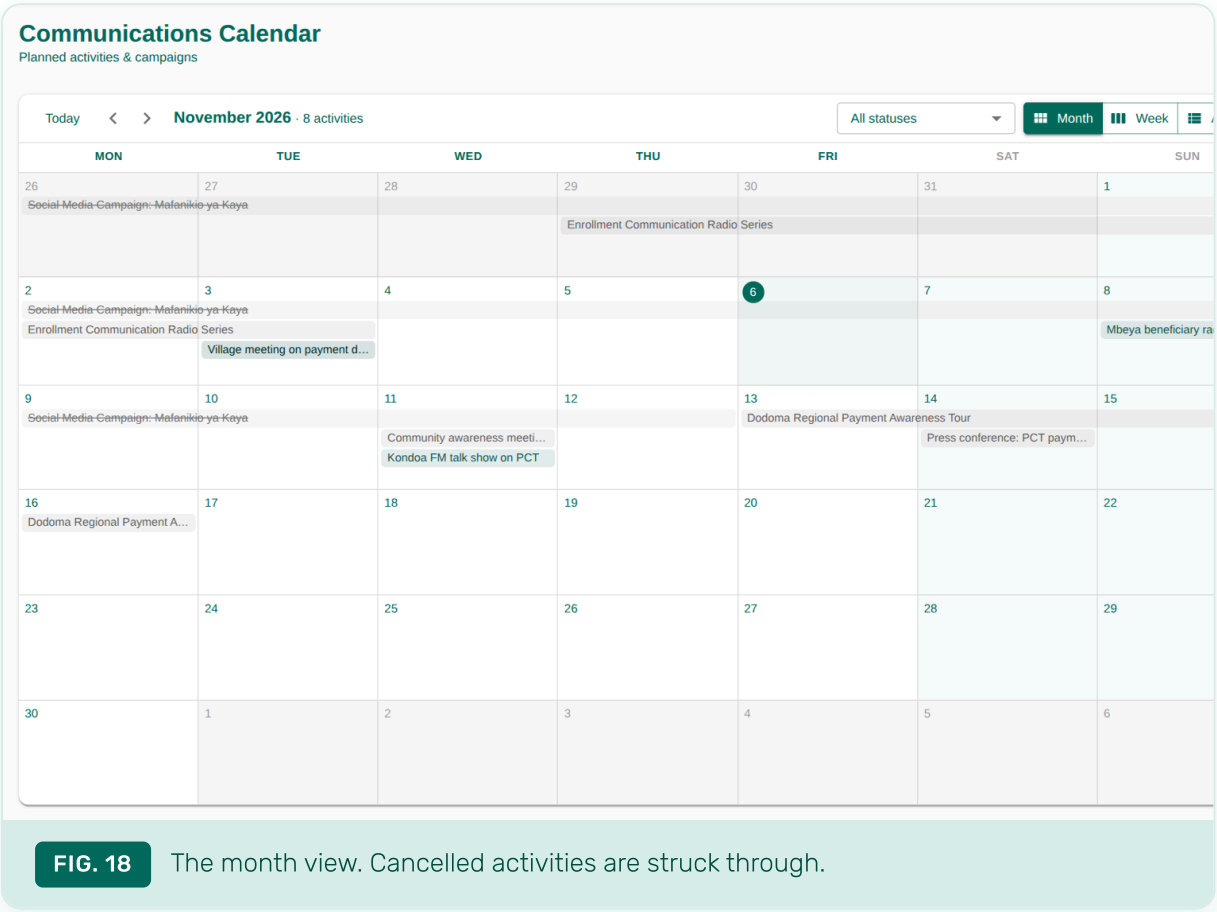


FIG. 18 The month view. Cancelled activities are struck through.

Dashboard

Communications ▸ Dashboard gives the numbers for reports:

- **Activities:** total, this week, upcoming, and by status, type and channel.
- **Audience reach:** planned against actual, and by level (National, Regional, PAA, Community).
- **Participants:** registered, attendance rate, attendance by gender.
- **Media coverage:** houses invited and reported, coverage rate, average quality.

Use the filters at the top: **From** and **To** (activities starting in that period) and **Region** (everything inside it is included). The numbers update when you change a filter.

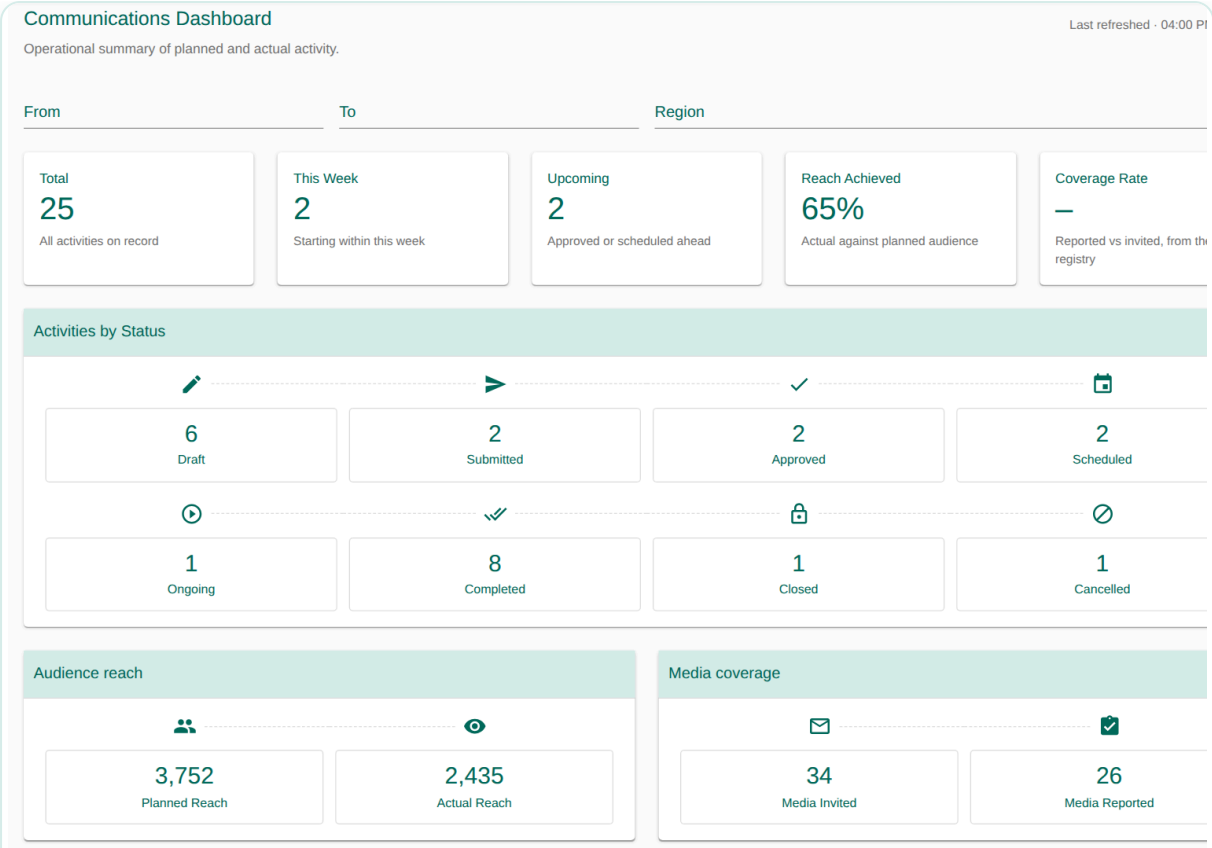


FIG. 19 The Dashboard with its filters, summary cards and status counts.

> The numbers are only as good as what the team records. An activity with no Participants or Media Coverage rows counts as zero reached.

11. Lesson 8 • Library, media houses and journalists

Library

Tab	What it holds	Used by
Templates	Ready-made messages: code, name, channel, subject, message	"Start from a template" in the News Feed
Stakeholder lists	Named lists of people (name, organisation, phone, email, location)	"Invite from a stakeholder list" in Participants
Assets	Logos, brand files, photos, videos, documents	Download and reuse

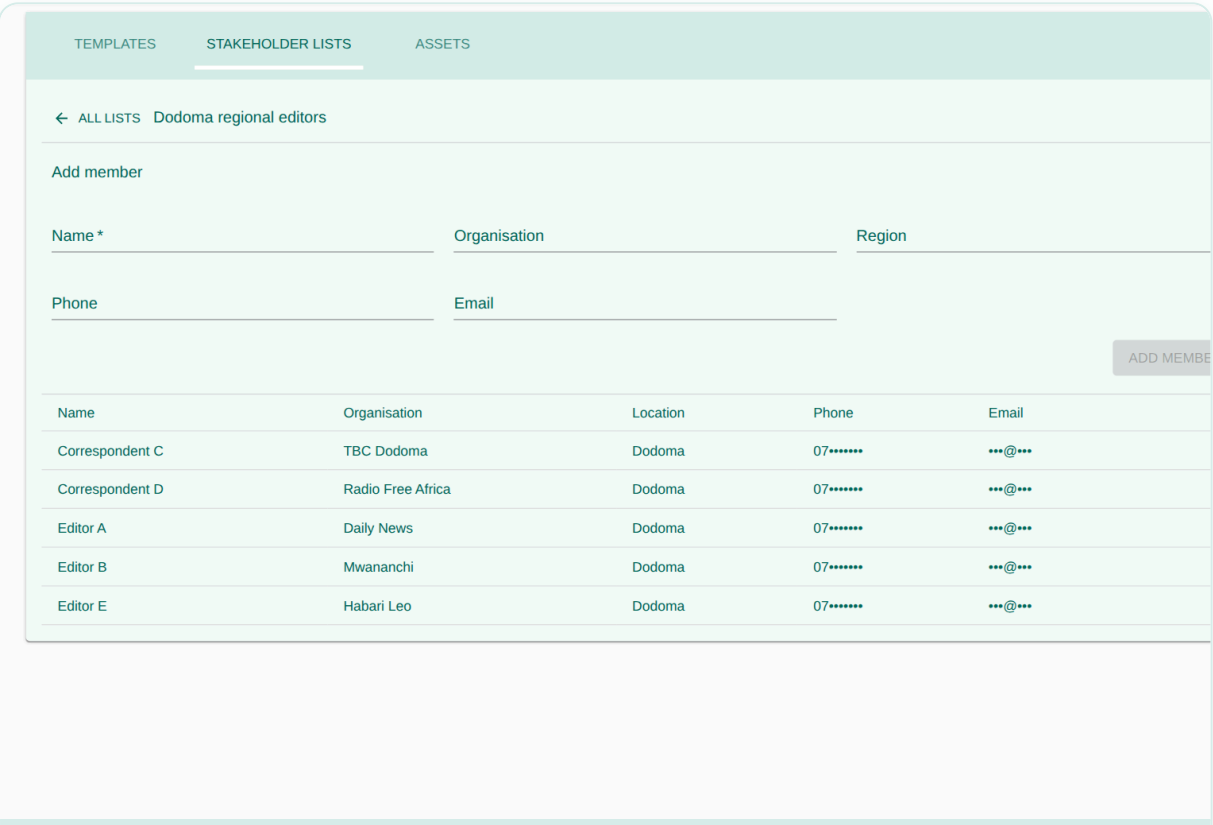


FIG. 20 The stakeholder list "Dodoma regional editors" and its members.

Media Houses

The official list of newspapers, radio and TV stations, websites and blogs. Each has a code such as `MH00012` made by the system, and a category (medium and reach). The quality column is the average of the ratings given in Media Coverage; you cannot type it.

Journalists

Media staff, each with a code such as `MJ00031`. A journalist belongs to a media house or is **freelance**. The record shows the stories they filed and their average quality.

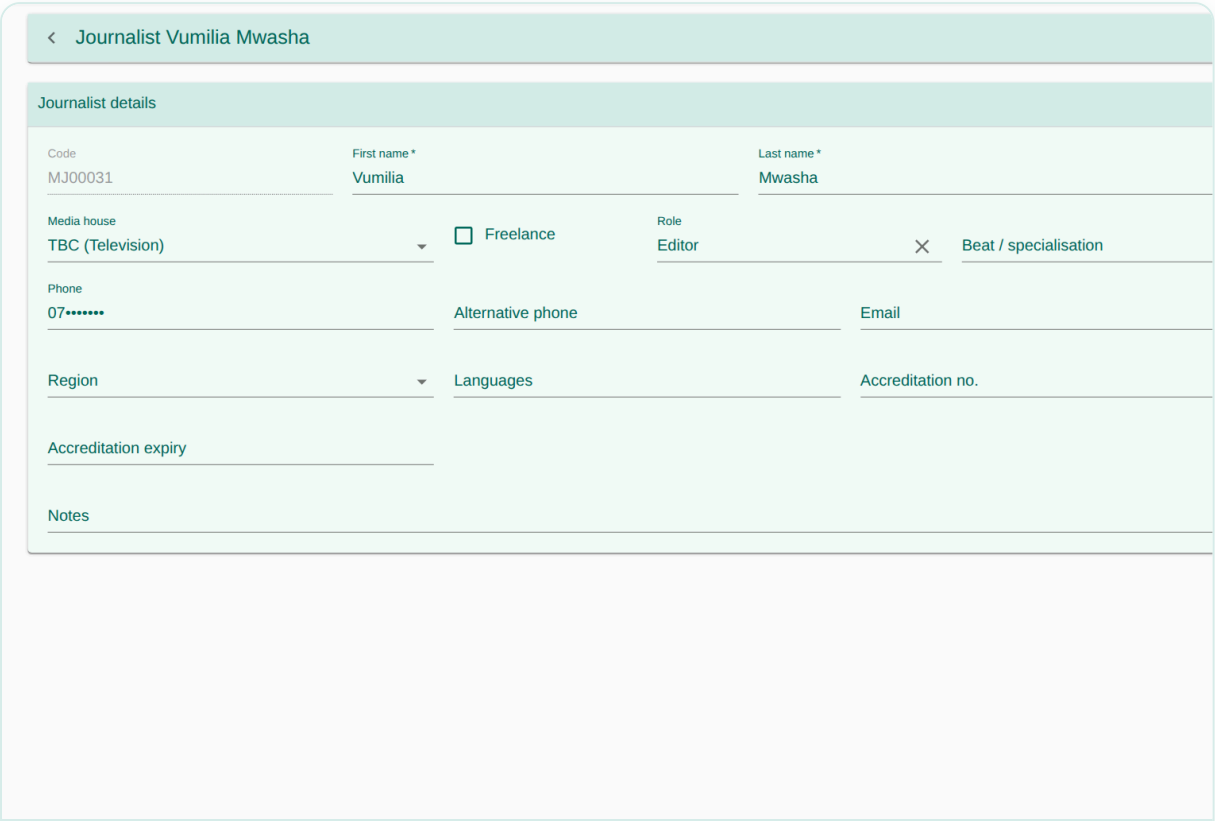


FIG. 21 A journalist record (phone masked).

> This list holds personal details. Do not copy it outside the system.

12. Known limits (tell trainees)

Tell trainees about these limits so they don't think they made a mistake.

#	What the user sees	What to do for now
1	**Mark as sent** only records that a message went out. The MIS sends no email or SMS.	Send messages the usual way, then mark them.
2	A rejected **activity** does not show why it was rejected. The Officer gets a bell notice, but without the reason. (For News Feed posts the reason is shown.)	The Manager tells the Officer directly.
3	Uploaded files may be lost when the server is updated, until the storage fix is applied.	Keep your own copy of important files.
4	Everyone with access sees the activities of all regions.	Use the filters (Activities list, Dashboard).

13. Practice exercises

> Do these on the **test server**, never on the live one.

Exercise 1 • Plan and approve

Officer + Manager • 20 min

1. Officer: create "Community awareness meeting, Kondoa" for next Tuesday, 09:00–12:00, area PCT, type Community Awareness Session.
2. Add one channel (Radio), one objective (target 50 people), two audience rows and yourself as Owner.
3. Submit it.
4. Manager: check the bell shows "… is awaiting your approval", and click it to open the activity.
5. Manager: reject it, and give the reason by phone.
6. Officer: check the bell shows "… was rejected". Revise, change the venue, Submit again.
7. Manager: Approve it. Officer: check the bell shows "… was approved".

Exercise 2 • Run it

Officer • 15 min

1. Schedule the activity.
2. Invite a stakeholder list, then add two people by hand.
3. Start the activity; mark 3 people Attended and 1 Absent. Complete it.
4. Check that "Actual Audience" now shows 3.

Exercise 3 • Media coverage

Officer • 10 min

1. Add two media houses, both invited.
2. Mark one as reported, with a link, the journalist and quality 4.
3. Open the Dashboard and find your numbers.

Exercise 4 • News Feed

Officer + Manager • 15 min

1. Officer: write an Announcement from a template, attach a PDF, Save draft, then Submit for approval.
2. Manager: check the post has no **Publish** button while it is pending. Open the bell notice and **Reject** it with the comment "Add the date".

3. Officer: check the red box shows “Add the date”. Fix the post and Submit for approval again.
4. Manager: approve it from **Approvals ▸ My approvals**, then pin it in the News Feed.
5. Officer: check the bell says the post was approved and published.
6. Log in as any other user: the announcement pops up. Dismiss it.
7. Officer: edit the published post and check that it goes back to Draft.

Exercise 5 • Results after the event

Officer • 10 min

1. On the activity from Exercise 2, type the Achieved value (pencil) and the Actual Reach on each audience row.
2. Add one feedback row and upload a photo in Attachments.
3. Open the Dashboard, choose this month and your region, and find your numbers.

14. Quick reference card

I want to…	Go to	Click
Plan an activity	Activities	+
Send it to my manager	the activity	**Submit**
See what waits for me	the bell, or Approvals ▸ My approvals	click the notice
Approve an activity	the bell notice, or the activity (Submitted)	**Approve** / **Reject**
Fix a rejected activity	the activity	**Revise**, then **Submit**
Record who came	Participants tab	status **Attended**
Invite a saved list	Participants tab	**Invite members**
Record a news story	Media Coverage tab	tick **Reported**, give **Quality**
Record a message I sent	Channels tab	**Mark as sent**
Record results	Objectives / Audience tab	pencil, then **Save**
Tell all staff something	News Feed	**Post an update…**
Send a post for approval	News Feed, my draft	**Submit for approval**
Approve a post	the bell notice, or Approvals ▸ My approvals	**Approve** / **Reject** (with a comment)
See the month	Calendar	**Month**
Get numbers for a report	Dashboard	**From**, **To**, **Region**

15. Words you will see

Word	Meaning
Activity	Any planned communication work: press conference, media mission, meeting, newsletter…
Event	An activity where people gather. The Events menu shows only these.
Status	The stage an activity is at (Draft, Submitted, Approved…)
Audience	The *groups* you want to reach and how many people
Participants	The *named people* invited or present
Stakeholder type	A group such as Journalist, Village Executive Officer or Beneficiaries, at a level (National, Regional, PAA, Community)
Stakeholder list	A saved list of named contacts you can invite in one click
Media house	A newspaper, radio, TV station, website or blog
Coverage	A story a media house published or broadcast about the activity
Channel	The way a message goes out: email, SMS, radio…
Template	A ready-made message you can reuse
Pin	Keep a post at the top of the News Feed
Clash	The same staff member or place booked for two activities at the same time
Maker / checker	One person prepares (maker), another approves (checker)
Bell	The notifications icon at the top of the screen: what waits for you and what was decided